

How Will Sharpe's 'Outsider Energy' Brought Mozart to Life in 'Amadeus'

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Growing up, Will Sharpe shuttled between Japan and England, never feeling fully at home in either. "People who have lived in different countries or who are mixed race, you do sometimes end up with this feeling that you're not really sure where your home is or how to identify," Sharpe says. That sense of being an outsider became a superpower when he landed the role of Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart in the Starz **limited series** Amadeus.

The show, adapted from Peter Shaffer's 1979 stage play, fictionalizes the bitter rivalry between Mozart and **court composer** Antonio Salieri. Sharpe's Mozart is a brilliant eccentric who uses music to express what he can't say in words and who constantly baffles those around him. "He doesn't know how to read a room," Sharpe explains. "There's a lot written **speculatively** about **neurodiversity**. And I tried not to be too literal about that or to **retro-diagnose** him, but [I] definitely wanted to play him as slightly 'other.'"

To prepare, Sharpe dove deep into the **physicality** of musicianship. He spent months learning specific piano pieces and practicing conducting. "There's this sense that Mozart was someone for whom music just fell out of the sky into his lap," he says. "But I was sort of curious to try and imagine: What does that actually look and feel like in his day-to-day life?"

Sharpe's recent roles have showcased his range: a tech bro in The White Lotus season 2, a collaborator with Lena Dunham on Too Much, and a supporting turn in the Oscar-winning A Real Pain. Working with Kieran Culkin and Jesse Eisenberg on that film, he witnessed a real-life version of the Mozart-Salieri dynamic. "Jesse [would come] in with a very specific plan... and Kieran was like, 'Why would I stand there?'" Sharpe recalls. "Even before we'd started rolling... they'd fallen into the same dynamic as the characters."

In Amadeus, Sharpe channels all that experience into a portrait of genius as both gift and burden. Salieri, he notes, feels "neglected by God [while] Mozart is getting all of the attention and is having music showered upon him." It's a brotherhood built on awe and resentment and Sharpe makes you feel every note of it.

Word Treasure

neurodiversity -- The idea that variations in how brains work, such as autism or ADHD, are natural differences, not defects.

retro-diagnose -- To use modern medical knowledge to guess what condition a historical figure might have had.

court composer -- A musician hired by a royal or imperial court to create music for ceremonies and entertainment, a prestigious job in past centuries.

limited series -- A TV show designed to tell a complete story in a short, fixed number of episodes, like a long movie.

speculatively -- In a way that forms a theory without firm evidence; guessing based on hints.

physicality -- The bodily aspect of an activity, especially how a performer uses movement

and physical presence in a role.

Background you need

Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart (1756-1791) was a child prodigy who composed over 600 works in his short life, yet he died in poverty at 35. The rumor that his colleague Antonio Salieri (a respected Italian court composer in Vienna) poisoned him was largely a 19th-century myth, but it inspired Peter Shaffer's 1979 play *Amadeus*, which uses a fictionalized rivalry to explore envy and the nature of genius.

The 1984 film adaptation of *Amadeus* won eight Academy Awards, though historians criticize its portrayal of Mozart as infantile and Salieri as a murderer. The new Starz limited series, starring Will Sharpe, is a more recent reimagining that can incorporate modern perspectives like the possible neurodiversity of Mozart.

Will Sharpe is a British-Japanese actor and filmmaker who first gained attention with his dark comedy series *Flowers* (2016). His roles in *The White Lotus* and *A Real Pain* have shown a talent for characters caught between worlds, a feeling he knows well from his own bicultural childhood.

Break it down

LEAD: Sharpe's own outsider identity becomes a superpower for playing Mozart.

ROLE CONCEPT: Mozart as an eccentric who doesn't read the room, probably neurodiverse.

+ SPECIFIC CHOICE: avoiding a literal retro-diagnosis, playing 'other'.

PREPARATION: physicality of learning piano and conducting to show genius as felt, not just gifted.

+ QUERY: imagining what it actually looked and felt like day-to-day.

ACTOR'S ARC: other roles -- tech bro, collaborator -- broaden his range; witness Eisenberg-Culkin dynamic.

+ PARALLEL: *A Real Pain*'s director/actor friction mirrors Salieri/Mozart.

THEMATIC CLOSE: Genius as both gift and burden; Salieri sees music showered on Mozart while he feels neglected.

+ BROTHERHOOD BUILT ON AWE AND RESENTMENT.

Why it matters

Portrayals like Sharpe's shape how young people understand historical genius, mental difference, and the pain of being an outsider -- showing that the line between gift and burden is thin, and that feeling 'other' can fuel great art.

Test what you remember

1. What personal background did Will Sharpe draw on to play Mozart?

- ☐ (A) Growing up in a musical family
- ☐ (B) Living between Japan and England and feeling like an outsider
- ☐ (C) Training as a classical pianist from age three
- ☐ (D) Being an only child

2. How did Sharpe approach the role of Mozart?

- ☐ (A) By trying to copy recordings of Mozart's own playing
- ☐ (B) By attempting to imagine what genius felt like day-to-day, being slightly 'other'
- ☐ (C) By strictly researching a medical diagnosis of autism
- ☐ (D) By using only historical documents and letters

3. What specific skills did Sharpe learn to prepare for playing Mozart?

- ☐ (A) Fencing and horseback riding
- ☐ (B) Singing opera and composing
- ☐ (C) Learning specific piano pieces and practicing conducting
- ☐ (D) Learning French and dancing

4. Which experience did Sharpe compare to the Mozart-Salieri dynamic?

- ☐ (A) His time on stage in Tokyo
- ☐ (B) Working with Kieran Culkin and Jesse Eisenberg on A Real Pain
- ☐ (C) A scene from The White Lotus season 2
- ☐ (D) His collaboration with Lena Dunham

5. In the story, how does Salieri feel toward Mozart?

- ☐ (A) Pure hatred
- ☐ (B) Indifference
- ☐ (C) A mix of awe and resentment
- ☐ (D) Fatherly affection

6. What is the original source of the TV show Amadeus?

- ☐ (A) A novel by Peter Shaffer
- ☐ (B) A 1979 stage play
- ☐ (C) A 2005 film
- ☐ (D) A biography of Mozart

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive: Sharpe's outsider perspective brings fresh humanity to a role often played as just a silly prodigy. His emphasis on neurodiversity can help audiences see a genius figure through a more empathetic, modern lens, encouraging acceptance of different minds.**
- 2. Negative / Critical: Fictionalized portraits of real figures can warp public understanding of history, and a 'neurodiverse' angle on Mozart risks turning a complex person into a modern label. Some purists may also object to actors without extensive classical music backgrounds taking such roles.**
- 3. Neutral / Analytical: Amadeus has always been less about Mozart and more about the torment of the also-talented Salieri. The play's enduring power lies in its study of envy and mediocrity, themes that transcend any single casting choice and remain relevant across eras.**
- 4. Forward-looking: As period dramas increasingly risk being seen as stale, a multicultural actor playing a historically 'other' Mozart could signal a shift toward more inclusive and psychologically nuanced casting -- and spark new debates about how we reconstruct historical figures on screen.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):